

A full-page photograph of a person rock climbing a large, dark, craggy boulder. The climber is wearing a black tank top and red shorts, and is positioned on the right side of the rock face. The boulder is situated in a riverbed, with water flowing around its base. The foreground is filled with smooth, light-colored river stones. In the background, there are more rocks and some evergreen trees under a clear blue sky. The text 'CHAPTER 4' and 'BLOCK PROGRAMMING' is overlaid in white, bold, sans-serif font in the upper center of the image.

CHAPTER 4

BLOCK PROGRAMMING

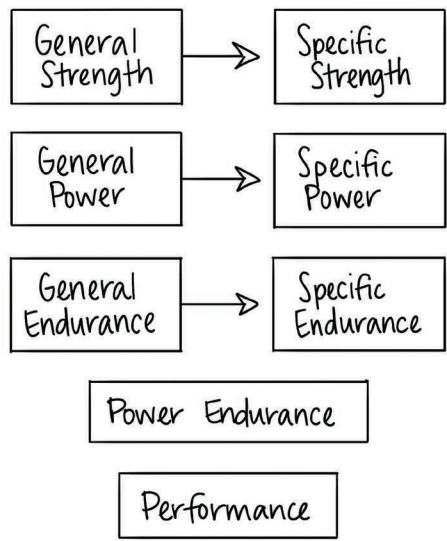
PHOTO: JULIE ELLISON

Block programming is simply a way of setting up your yearly cycle in a way that your body is allowed to adapt primarily to one facet of your fitness, while maintaining the others. The only real difference between this programming and classical periodization is the focus on maintenance of relevant fitness qualities throughout the entire (months long) training cycle. The simplest way to apply the blocks is much like we saw in the Level III example in the previous section: stick with a nonlinear cycle, but lean toward a specific goal.

Most climbers can get away without adding this much complexity to their training. If you are not yet training regularly, progressing the difficulty, and really pushing hard at the boulders or crags, there is not going to be any magic in structuring your training. It is only when you already have a regular training schedule, when you've worked up to plateaus, and when you have spent long seasons fighting against the same performance level that you need to look at complex programming methods.

My block programs are each focused on one of the primary fitness qualities we use in climbing: strength, power, endurance, and power endurance. I also have built one that is aimed at training during a performance phase. I have further developed the strength, power, and endurance blocks into both general and specific categories. By developing general qualities in each of these facets of fitness, we can improve our fitness more quickly, and then apply it to sport-specific movement in the specific block. If we go specific too early, our overall fitness will stall out and we will never fully realize our true potential.

The blocks are as follows:



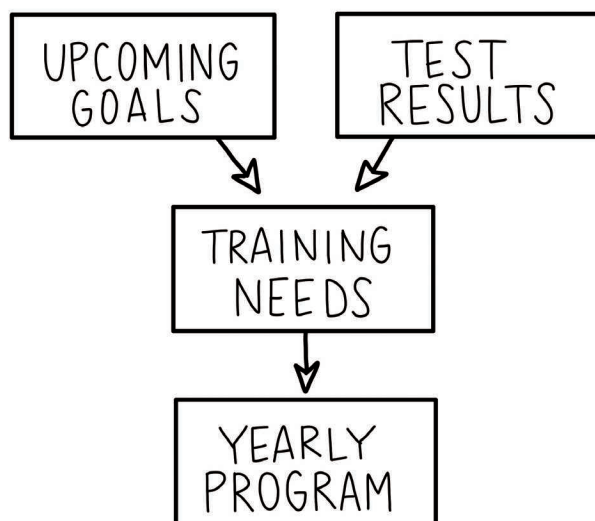
The best method for training these phases tends to be to stack a general phase and a specific phase together. For example, you train 4 weeks of general strength, followed by 4 weeks of specific strength, and then transition to do the same for power, and so on.

We don't spend time on a general power endurance phase because of the difficult nature of the training. Too much time training in the lactic zone tends to bleed both strength and power, so we use power endurance training sparingly and only during short peaking periods a couple of times a year.

Naturally, we don't need a general performance phase, either. Performance is performance.

YEARLY PLANNING FOR BLOCKS

Your yearly plan should be built around your training needs. Your training needs will be determined by both upcoming goals and testing. If you are planning on free climbing a big wall, you'll likely need a lot of general endurance and strength training in the off season. If you are a competition boulderer, you'll need lots of power and power endurance.



Months out from these goals, your training should focus on the main things that are challenging for you. These can be determined through testing and through observation of performance. You should run a short testing protocol at the beginning of every 4 week phase, not only to determine what your weaknesses are, but also to assure that the values you are trying to hold on to are being maintained. This testing is covered later in the **Simple Testing** section.

Programming and the execution of the program can make or break a seasoned climber. Most of us fall into the same habits and routines in training season after season. If your tests and your friends' observations and your performances all indicate that you lack general endurance, your program should probably involve a lot of general endurance. The problem is that you haven't been doing endurance *because* you aren't good at it...and probably won't without a lot of structure and feedback.

We erroneously think that if we could just enhance our strengths a little bit more, or just add a bit more volume in the facets we really like, we'd be able to dispense with things like endurance training. In most sports, this is true. If you don't like running fast, you can do ultras and succeed based on your ability to hang with it for hours. If you don't like running for hours, you can be a sprinter. In climbing, even if we only boulder or only trad climb, we still have to develop all of our systems. Boulderers need endurance for long problems, but also for long days, and for multiple days in a row - not to mention hiking pads up into the wilderness at 12,000 feet. The inverse is also true - even a climber who spends all of their time at pumpy enduro crags occasionally needs to drop the hammer and do a big move or hold a small pocket. Power and strength enhance endurance tremendously, and make its application much easier. No one wants to be able to do unlimited 5.0 climbing... except maybe an ultramarathoner.

I will cover specifics of a couple of example programs at the end of the book. However, here are a few good pointers for building blocks of training:

1. It's almost always a good idea to start any long cycle of training with a General Endurance block. Yes, I know that power and strength are foundational, but many of us really drop off on the capacity end of things if we've taken some time off or even if we've been focusing hard on one

project. Getting your endurance up at the beginning gives you the ability to train - at all - for the planned hours in upcoming phases.

2. Almost always, specific phases should follow right after a general phase in the same type of training. Think about the general phase as building the sword and the specific as sharpening it. It is very hard to build high levels of any type of fitness by specific means alone. Skills limit your ability to do a lot of volume, and the fingers and toes limit your ability to exert sufficient levels of force early on. For example, doing pull-ups on a 10mm edge (very specific) limits your ability to gain strength in the upper body because the limiter becomes the fingers instead of the muscles of the upper arm and back.
3. Power Endurance (PE), even though it's the monster that rears its ugly head every time you fail, should only be trained after building sufficiently high levels of Specific Endurance and Power. You need to create an ideal situation for getting the most out of a PE phase, which includes being able to generate high levels of force, and to have the aerobic capacity to recover well from the sessions. Although PE blocks are 4 weeks long in this book, many climbers won't even need that long to "peak" their fitness. Pay attention to this as you do your own training. There is nothing wrong with keeping these to two-week blocks!
4. Recovery time is important. I advocate for 4 weeks of recovery per year, and this can be in the form of several shorter week-long blocks, two 2-week blocks, or even a full cycle of no training. Yes, you can still climb and exercise, but let off the gas and emphasize getting refreshed. Go on a trip with your family.

GENERAL PHASES	SPECIFIC PHASES
Focus on optimizing energy production	Focus on optimizing energy expenditure
Focus on large muscle groups	Focus on sport-specific muscles
Focus on a wide variety of movements	Focus almost exclusively on sport movements
Focus on multiple exercise durations	Focus on durations specific to the sport or goal
Work on eliminating weak links in performance	Work on maximizing athlete's strengths

STRUCTURE OF NONLINEAR BLOCK CYCLES

This is where the programming gets interesting. I built this block-style program after hearing from so many readers of the original Logical Progression and their success with programs like the one outlined in the Level III section earlier. With a block program, you have one training focus - a single facet you are trying to improve. This will be the main system you train for of two out of every three sessions. The third session is a maintenance session, combining the other facets of your training into one workout, and done at a level just enough to keep those values up.

For example, A typical General Strength Block would feature a three-session cycle of Strength, Strength, and Maintenance. This structure holds true for almost all of the training you'll do in any block. There are a couple of programming exceptions, and I'll cover those in the specific sections for each block.

When building your program, you simply need to select two sessions from the list of sessions in your upcoming block and plan to do them as the main focus of your week. You'll build a third session that is meant to just maintain the other facets of your fitness. It is a rare climber that I'd suggest needs to train more than three days per week, especially since I recommend you go climbing throughout the training plans. If you are feeling like three days is not enough, I'll wager that your intensity is too low in the training sessions. On the other hand, if you are feeling like you can't keep up at three days per week, that is perfectly normal and you can back off to fewer sessions.

The main idea here is that we adapt to overload based on the number of times we are exposed to it, not based on the number of weeks we are spending in that phase. If you do a 4-week strength block as suggested in this book (3 sessions per week - two of them strength and one maintenance), you'll end up with 8 strength sessions in a phase before switching to other training. Thus if you can't hang with that volume, you simply need to let the cycles go longer.

You can, of course, be more flexible with your scheduling than above. The important things to keep in mind are that if your sessions get to average more than 4 days apart, your progress will slow and your ability to maintain the non-focus fitness becomes more challenging. If you are feeling like sticking with even a 2-day per week plan is a stretch between training and climbing, you are probably better off doing a standard 3-session nonlinear plan, or sticking with General Endurance training, as one of the primary results of that block is increased work capacity.

If life is too busy to fit climbing in - and I mean this with all seriousness - something is amiss. Does your job really require that much time of you? Do you really need that particular job? Do you have a timewasting habit that is sucking up inordinate amounts of time, such as social media or television? It's not the climbing

that matters so much as the living you do when focused on a hard physical goal. Don't lose this gift.

Suggested Strength Phase:

	MON.	TUE.	WED.	THUR.	FRI.	SAT.	SUN.
Week 1	Strength 1		Maintenance 1		Strength 2		
Week 2	Strength 3		Maintenance 2		Strength 4		
Week 3	Strength 5		Maintenance 3		Strength 6		
Week 4	Strength 7		Maintenance 4		Strength 8		

Lower-Frequency Strength Phase:

	MON.	TUE.	WED.	THUR.	FRI.	SAT.	SUN.
Week 1	Strength 1			Maintenance 1			
Week 2	Strength 3			Strength 3			
Week 3	Maintenance 2			Strength 4			
Week 4	Strength 5			Maintenance 3			
Week 5	Strength 6			Strength 7			
Week 6	Maintenance 4			Strength 8			

THE TRAINING BLOCKS

The training blocks below are the ones we use to focus training on specific areas of climbing fitness. As you'll recall, we almost always want to follow a general phase with a specific one, and no, you shouldn't just do specific training. General training will build your capacity (think of it like working to earn a lot of money) and specific training will build your system power (think of this like spending money, which is dependent on the amount you have saved up).

GENERAL STRENGTH

As climbers, the need for stronger fingers is obvious. We easily recognize that if we were just able to hold on a little harder things would get easier in a hurry. We also recognize that developing the ability to pull is of significant advantage. Between these two factors, you've covered most of the bases, and many of us stop there.

I encourage you to go one step further, though, and add a few more movements to fully develop their athleticism. By adding in some "non-specific" strength movements and some mobility drills, we can achieve much more than we can with pull-ups and edge hangs. First, we reduce the chance of injury by balancing strength across key joints. Second, we allow full development of pulling strength by reducing inhibition associated with a strength imbalance, and third, we re-learn full joint mobility, to regain normal movement in the key joints.

Imagine you are building yourself a house. You're just planning a shack, really, four walls and a door and maybe a window. You flatten out the ground, level it, and start laying down logs for the walls. Once the walls are in, you put in a nice floor and a roof and a window, and the door. Mountain shack done. You are alone in the wilderness and can keep the snow off.

A couple years later you meet someone and get married and all of a sudden, the shack is too small. You add a room similar to the first. All good. Then the kids come. One, two, three... You build out to the edge of your property, adding a room at a time, but the place is still small, so you decide to add a second floor. The floors are warped and uneven by this time, so you tear out that whole room, and put in a concrete floor. This process happens again and again until your whole two-story house is on a slab of concrete.

Then, the house burns down. When it comes time to rebuild, you decide on building to three stories. You tear out the slab at great effort, then dig down and pour a full foundation with footers to support the greater weight of the house.

How much easier would it have been to start with a good foundation? How much better would the house's durability been? What if you build such a strong and stable foundation that it would never be a place where your house's structure could fail?

This foundation is your general strength. General strength is where I get the most pushback from climbers, moreso even than with general endurance exercises. Climbers understand the need for specific strength, but why would they need to use their pressing muscles or antagonists, other than for a little "balancing out?" Why would they need stronger legs? After all, they are "strong enough to hike all day."

General strength training is about force production capability and learning to create tension. We deadlift and press and squat and do high-force core training not to be good at those exercises, but to learn about how to use our bodies in high-force situations. A side effect of getting generally strong is that you generally don't get hurt by occasional high-force situations in your specific training.

"Strong people are harder to kill, and more useful in general."

- Mark Rippetoe

The general strength block cycle features two resistance training sessions and one power / endurance maintenance session. Climbers who have a long training history can build the strength sessions as they see fit, keeping in mind the goal of actually *getting stronger* over the 4 weeks of this cycle. Likewise, the session dedicated to power and endurance maintenance can be set up any way you'd like, as long as you are able to maintain your levels in those categories.

The difficulty, with any of these cycles, is to truly prioritize strength and to train the other two as little as possible. I remind you that you are using this program because your progress has halted on the train everything, all the time, plan. Keep good notes, stick to the plan, trust the body.

In the section that follows, I will detail the training plans that have worked well for our athletes in a general strength block. I'll include several session structures, but I suggest you stick with just one strength session structure and one maintenance session for an entire cycle, which will be 8 strength sessions and 4 maintenance sessions for most people. If, in your 4-week cycle you get slightly ahead (doing more than the typical three sessions per week) or fall slightly behind, great. If you get way ahead, and feel like you can do 5+ sessions per week, you're clearly not training very heavy. Likewise, if you can't sustain 2-3 sessions per week of strength, your capacity is probably not up to par and you might need to do a few cycles of general endurance.

The recommended General Strength Sessions include:

- Integrated Strength (P.97)
- High Load Strength (P.95)

General Strength Cycle

GENERAL
STRENGTH
SESSION 1

GENERAL
STRENGTH
SESSION 2

ENDURANCE
& POWER
MAINTENANCE

SPECIFIC STRENGTH

Specific strength is the cycle where we take the gains in strength from the general cycle and apply them to climbing. Although you will have been climbing, and training some specific aspects of strength, in the last cycle, here we go all-in on the climbing strength. Many climbers opt to train specific strength without addressing general strength, thinking they can shortcut that step. I caution you against it. Climbing-specific training is too technical and relies on your fingertips and toes too much to create very high loads on your systems. Thus, although your fingers may feel very tired after a session, the bigger muscles of your body and those of your midsection are hardly taxed.

In specific strength, you'll focus on more movement (using a system board or campus board rather than a hangboard in some instances), and more single-arm or single-leg exercises. You'll also do more combined skills, such as pulling up on edges, doing compound weight exercises, or specific strength skills in the bouldering gym.

Although the focus is on strength, some of your specific drills will touch on power training, which is simply strength done at higher speeds. This is natural, and is a fundamental bridge to cross in climbing. Later, during endurance cycles and performance cycles, you'll train the two together many sessions.

As with general strength, the normal sequence of sessions is Strength, Strength, Maintenance. You will select one (sometimes two) specific sessions from the suggestions below, and do them for 4 weeks, which is 7-9 sessions for most athletes. You'll also have an endurance and power maintenance session every third workout. This can be the same maintenance session you did in the general phase, or you can switch to a different one.

The recommended Specific Strength sessions include:

- Full Combination Strength (P.101)
- Integrated Boulder (P.105)
- Combined Circuits (P.107)
- Go A Hundred Finger Strength (P.110)
- Max Hangs + Max Pulls (P.116)

Specific Strength Cycle

SPECIFIC
STRENGTH
SESSION 1

SPECIFIC
STRENGTH
SESSION 2

ENDURANCE
& POWER
MAINTENANCE

GENERAL POWER

In the general power phase, the whole goal is to take the newly gained strength from the previous phase (*always* start power phases when your strength is high), and turn it into explosiveness. You'll use many different speeds of exercise and many different loads in this phase, but all power exercises are done with the mindset of creating high force quickly. In this cycle, you'll do two power-based sessions in a row, followed by a strength and

endurance maintenance session. My favorite set-up is to do two different power workouts each week. For example, I would do one Complex Method session, rest a day, then do an Integrated Power session, rest a day, then do the maintenance work.

The value of general power development should not be underestimated. As with strength, very-high levels of power are hard to develop in sport-specific movements alone. What we are working toward in these general phases is not “getting back in shape” for the power, strength, etc. we knew before...it is about attaining new levels of performance. What you did last time simply isn’t enough for what you want next time.

The general power phase should include plenty of bouldering, of course. One thing people lose sight of with any of the training plans we put out is that a large percentage of your total work time should still be done by moving between small holds on a boulder, cliff, or climbing wall. In the general training phase for power, you’ll also be moving big weights, jumping high, and resting a lot between sets.

There are many options for training power. A huge focus of the strength and conditioning industry is on developing speed and explosiveness, so taking lessons from this field is not wrong. If you have a power plan for the weight room, this is a great time to try it out in your training. Remember, though, to keep the volumes low, the intensity high, and to keep the goal of climbing harder in your mind.

Testing at the beginning of the phase should consist of a Vertical Jump Test (P.89) and the 10-second Push-Up Test (P.90). These will give you a good idea whether you are gaining power in your training.

General Power sessions include:

- 3x2 Power (P.119)
- Integrated Power (P.120)

- The Complex Method (P.120)

General Power Cycle

GENERAL
POWER
SESSION 1

GENERAL
POWER
SESSION 2

ENDURANCE
& POWER
MAINTENANCE

SPECIFIC POWER

Now we're getting down to business. Specific Power really feels like climbing training. You jump and explode and catch small edges and get to yell on hard movements...but gains from this type of training without a base of general strength and power are fairly limited. If you do come into this phase having done your work in general strength and power, you can expect better results, lower injury potential, and a higher capacity for hard work.

Specific power is where you teach your “climbing body” to utilize your “athlete body” power. Many people who really get into the weightroom portion of training lose contact with the climbing side of things and can never make the connection. For me, it's as much bringing the ability to put forth really focused and challenging efforts (that are so easy to learn in the weight room) to climbing.

Like General Power, the goal has to remain giving 100% on each set. Fatigue should be avoided in all of these sessions, even if it means resting “too much.” If you can harness the discipline to rest between hard sets or groups, you'll see your ability to put forth sustained hard efforts in later training phases.

Specific Power sessions include:

- Integrated Boulder (P.121)
- Boulder / Campus (P.123)

GENERAL ENDURANCE

General endurance seems to be a deal-breaker for most athletes I consult with. Either they think it's ridiculous and would never do it, or they are so tied to doing it that it negatively affects their ability to train for anything else. When we look at general endurance training for climbing, it is important to look at it in terms of needs. Climbers need enough endurance or capacity to train an entire:

- **Session:** We want to be able to do a whole workout, whether for strength, power, or endurance, and not “tap out” because we don’t have the basic stamina to exercise for an hour or two.
- **Week of Training:** Many climbers lack the capacity to perform a planned week of training. Maybe they train harder than prescribed early in the week or maybe they linger at the gym a bit longer than planned, or maybe they like to finish each session with a “good pump.” No matter what the cause, by the end of a given training week, many of us under-perform out of fatigue.
- **4-Week Cycle:** In general, training cycles increase in difficulty and volume as they progress. Many of us can’t make this leap because week one is too close to our maximum capacity to begin with. By week 4, we are actually decreasing durations and intensities - yet thinking the training is great because of the fatigue and soreness we are experiencing - and are losing out on the effectiveness of a cycled program.

In the general endurance block, we are going to build the basic capacity to train. There will be very little getting pumped and there will be a lot of general movement. For years, I beat the drum of “strength above all else,” not realizing that to train strength, you needed the basic ability to exercise *at all*, first.

In this block, you'll build the foundation upon which you can build specific endurance on the rock, will reinforce your body's ability to deliver the good stuff to your tissues and move the bad stuff out of them, and will create a body that responds better to high intensity efforts.

General Endurance sessions include:

- Cardiac Output (P.125)
- Alactic Capacity Circuits (P.127)
- Extensive Endurance Interval Combinations (P.130)
- Spartacus Circuits (P.133)

General Endurance Cycle

GENERAL
ENDURANCE
SESSION 1

GENERAL
ENDURANCE
SESSION 2

POWER &
STRENGTH
MAINTENANCE

SPECIFIC ENDURANCE

In general endurance training, we try to develop the endurance capacity of the body's muscles, including the heart and pulmonary muscles. General Endurance also aims to improve the overall function of the energy systems' capacities, and thus should be done year-round...but with greater focus early in the training phases. In contrast, Specific Endurance is the body's ability to use this energy production effectively within the context of directed climbing training or in performance on the rock. Power output and energy use are more important to focus on in later stages of the training, when potential should have already been addressed.

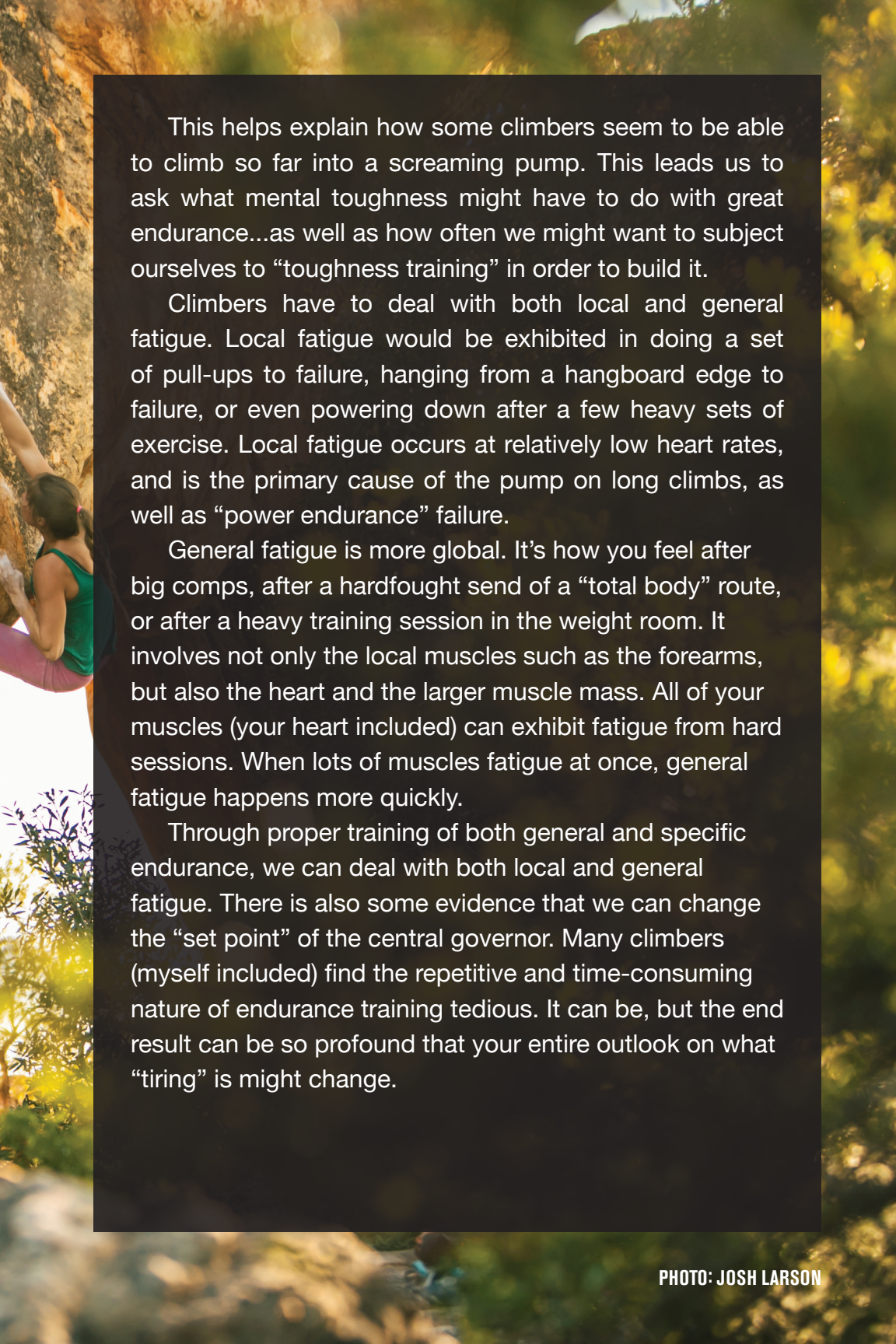
UNDERSTANDING FATIGUE

I am not in love with the word “endurance.” To me, it is too broad a term, and leads us too easily to thinking of a hard-breathing, sweating athlete putting in one more mile on the track. It leads us to think too easily that if only we can simulate the need to bring oxygen in, we’ll somehow improve our ability to withstand getting pumped at the top of a climb.

There are four main ways climbers exhibit fatigue when climbing:

1. Getting pumped on a route.
2. Seeing a decline in power on continuous moves.
3. Lacking energy to complete pitches later in the day.
4. Having a hard time recovering between climbing days or training sessions.

The brain and nervous system play a big part in fatigue. Where we used to believe that fatigued muscles were primarily a result of chemical and mechanical processes local to the muscles and the vascular system, sports science is beginning to understand that there is a central governor in the brain that drives much of fatigue. There is clear evidence that lack of oxygen and build-up of waste products are not the only issues. The brain monitors and controls fatigue to prevent possible damage to the organism, primarily by regulating electrical impulses to the muscle.

A woman in a green tank top and pink leggings is climbing a rock face. The background is a blurred forest scene with sunlight filtering through the trees.

This helps explain how some climbers seem to be able to climb so far into a screaming pump. This leads us to ask what mental toughness might have to do with great endurance...as well as how often we might want to subject ourselves to “toughness training” in order to build it.

Climbers have to deal with both local and general fatigue. Local fatigue would be exhibited in doing a set of pull-ups to failure, hanging from a hangboard edge to failure, or even powering down after a few heavy sets of exercise. Local fatigue occurs at relatively low heart rates, and is the primary cause of the pump on long climbs, as well as “power endurance” failure.

General fatigue is more global. It’s how you feel after big comps, after a hardfought send of a “total body” route, or after a heavy training session in the weight room. It involves not only the local muscles such as the forearms, but also the heart and the larger muscle mass. All of your muscles (your heart included) can exhibit fatigue from hard sessions. When lots of muscles fatigue at once, general fatigue happens more quickly.

Through proper training of both general and specific endurance, we can deal with both local and general fatigue. There is also some evidence that we can change the “set point” of the central governor. Many climbers (myself included) find the repetitive and time-consuming nature of endurance training tedious. It can be, but the end result can be so profound that your entire outlook on what “tiring” is might change.

In the specific phase, we look to increase power output at any given level of internal load. This means that at the same heart rate, perceived exertion, or blood lactate level, you can work harder. We increase the number of climbing-specific drills and the percentage of time spent focused on local forearm muscular endurance. Finally, we aim to more closely simulate the work-to-rest ratios associated with performance, whether that means competition bouldering, hard redpointing, or big wall speed climbing.

As with each phase in this book, you'll aim to do two specific endurance sessions and one maintenance session (strength and power) each week.

Specific Endurance session include:

- Alactic Capacity Circuits (P.135)
- Long Traverse-to-Problem (P.139, "Long T2P")
- Low-Load Density (P.141)

Specific Endurance Cycle

GENERAL
ENDURANCE
SESSION 1

GENERAL
ENDURANCE
SESSION 2

POWER &
STRENGTH
MAINTENANCE

POWER-ENDURANCE

Power-endurance: it's the quality that everyone thinks they need more of. It's that system we use as our forearms swell, our footwork fails, and we grope higher and higher hoping that the rest stance above is good enough to get some relief. I wrote a whole book about methods of developing this quality, and I have something to tell you. I wish I knew then what I know now.

The biggest issue with any power-endurance (PE) training is the transient nature of this fitness. Thankfully, it ramps up quite quickly, because the body has a hard time sustaining all the metabolic demands of maintaining it. Power-endurance is an ability that is the sum of several complex systems and abilities, and is much more than lactic power. Getting to high levels of PE requires highly developed explosive power, strength, and local aerobic endurance.

In this phase, we “put the icing on the cake” in honing your physical development as a climber. We should look at this as a “lactic system peaking cycle” much more than a developmental cycle, and this is exactly why we don’t have a general and a specific power endurance phase. This is when you get to let your animal brain get the feeling of real fatigue. This is when you get to wake up sore and leave the gym so pumped you can’t open your car door. This is also the time to build your excitement for sending the hardest routes of the year of going on a trip.

Similar to the other blocks, you’ll spend one session per week on maintenance, this time by keeping the fingers strong and doing some very easy Extensive Endurance climbing. At the crag, you will be starting to put work in on redpoint projects or hard onsights, but you will still be operating around 80% until the last week of the phase. Pay attention to recovery. If you can’t take 3 days per week of the training (as indicated by flat or declining performance), backing off to one session every three days is fine. If you can handle more than three, your sessions are probably not hard enough.

Power Endurance Training sessions include:

- Timed Combined Circuits (P.142)
- Rhythm Intervals (P.143)
- Campus Foot-On Ladders (P.145)
- High-Load Density (P.147)
- Complexes (P.148)

Power-Endurance Cycle

POWER-
ENDURANCE
SESSION 1

POWER-
ENDURANCE
SESSION 2

ENDURANCE &
STRENGTH
MAINTENANCE

PERFORMANCE

Switching over to performance is surprisingly hard for many athletes. They are so used to the pace of hard training weeks, so used to feeling slightly beat-down, that backing off on loads and feeling rested makes them anxious - and often they can't comply with a lower-intensity prescription. They feel that unless they are pushing hard, they are going backward.

The way that training works is to overload and recover the system. This happens on many levels:

- Overload during a boulder problem, rest before the next one.
- Overload during a workout, rest until the next training day.
- Overload for 3 weeks, recover during the 4th one.
- Overload for a training cycle, back off on training so that maximum performance is possible.

Although, emotionally, many of us can't let go of that beat-down feeling of training hard, we'll never see peak performances until we do. In the introduction to this book, and again throughout it, I urge you to maintain all your facets of fitness throughout each training cycle, performance time is the one possible exception. If

we see slight declines in strength or even power, it's OK because we are allowing you to perform your best in the sport you are doing all this training for in the first place.

So, what are the training needs during a Performance Phase? For most of us, simply going back to a normal Logical Progression nonlinear cycle of strength - power - endurance is enough. It is critical, though, to aim for lower-volume sessions each time you are in the gym, with a mind toward walking out the door feeling pretty good and capable of more. Save your hard work for climbing days.

Since you are going to be emphasizing climbing during this time, the cycle might be very slow to progress. A 4-week performance phase might look like this:

IN-SEASON CYCLE - GENERAL

	MON.	TUE.	WED.	THUR.	FRI.	SAT.	SUN.
Week 1	Strength Training		Redpoint Climbing	Power Training		Redpoint Climbing	
Week 2	Redpoint Climbing		Redpoint Climbing	Endurance Climbing		Redpoint Climbing	
Week 3	Strength Training		Redpoint Climbing	Power Training		Redpoint Climbing	Redpoint Climbing
Week 4			Redpoint Climbing	Endurance Training		Redpoint Climbing	Redpoint Climbing

Depending on the nature of your performance goals, you can make slight adjustments to the plan. For example, a boulderer in a performance phase is probably hitting strength and power very hard, and might not need to train those values outside performance days. However, the athlete's capacity might suffer due to the longer rest periods between problems and more rest days. In such a case, the athlete's training might follow a sequence of endurance - power-endurance - endurance - power, or something similar.

IN-SEASON CYCLE - BOULDERING

	MON.	TUE.	WED.	THUR.	FRI.	SAT.	SUN.
Week 1	Endurance Training		Bouldering		Bouldering	Power Endurance Training	
Week 2	Bouldering		Bouldering			Bouldering	Endurance Training
Week 3		Bouldering	Power Training		Bouldering		Bouldering
Week 4	Endurance Training		Bouldering			Bouldering	Power Endurance Training

For a redpoint climber, endurance and power-endurance are taken care of pretty well in a performance phase. You might see a slight decline in capacity (you tend to do fewer total pitches when aiming to send hard ones), but maintaining a bit of strength or power is very useful. Even on hard redpoints, it is very rare for us to maximally tax our top-end strength. If you're lucky, you'll be on a road trip or vacationing on a limestone-covered island for your performance phase.

A little bit of training, even at the end of performance days, can go a long way toward keeping you fit for a long trip. In the example below, I suggest training strength and power the day after a redpoint day. However, on a road trip or for someone who has a high work capacity, it might be useful to train the evening after a redpoint climbing day. This takes a lot of discipline and also takes a great deal of awareness around how your body is feeling - it's not just an opportunity for a beat-down.

IN-SEASON CYCLE - REDPOINTING

	MON.	TUE.	WED.	THUR.	FRI.	SAT.	SUN.
Week 1	Strength & Power Training		Redpointing	Strength & Power Training		Redpointing	Redpointing
Week 2	Strength & Power Training		Redpointing		Redpointing	Strength & Power Training	
Week 3	Redpointing	Strength & Power Training		Redpointing		Redpointing	Redpointing
Week 4	Strength & Power Training		Redpointing		Redpointing	Strength & Power Training	